

The Accords were completed in the early hours of July 21, but the clocks had been stopped to give the impression that it was still July 20—the deadline given by French prime minister Pierre Mendès-France.



Interested parties

A plenary session of the Geneva Conference assembles representatives of all the states with an interest in the Korean or Indochinese Wars. The most effective negotiations were those between France and the Viet Minh.

External pressures

Despite their military successes, the Viet Minh were also under pressure to reach an agreement. The Soviet Union and China wanted an easing of relations with the West. The Chinese communists in particular needed a period of peace to consolidate their revolution and recover from their losses in the Korean War. Fearing American military intervention in Vietnam that might prolong the conflict indefinitely, China urged Ho Chi Minh to seek a compromise and postpone total victory. British Foreign Secretary Sir Anthony Eden also put his weight behind a compromise deal, having envisaged the division of Vietnam into North and South from an early stage.

The United States might have been expected to take a leading part in the negotiations, but it did not. The American Secretary of State, John Foster Dulles, more or less boycotted the conference because of his fierce dislike of communists. Dulles's deputy, Walter Bedell Smith, did take part, but to no great effect.

In the end, an agreement was reached through direct talks between Mendès-France and the Viet Minh representative Pham Van Dong. The French insisted on Cambodia and Laos becoming independent on French terms, which sidelined revolutionary movements allied to the Viet Minh. In Vietnam, the focus on an immediate deal to end the fighting and secure a withdrawal of French forces resulted in fundamental issues being evaded or postponed.